

THE SQUARED CIRCLE

'Entertainment'

Written by

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BLACK.

Then, the roar of crowd fades in, and --

INT. LITTLE CAESAR'S ARENA - WWE PAY PER VIEW

Lights shine on thousands of fans cheering on as TWO MEN beat the crap out of each other half naked in a ring in the middle of the arena.

MIKE ASH (O.C.)

If you're just joining us now, we are LIVE! In a sold out arena as everyone's favorite champion, Max Freedom, defends his title against the man who is willing to do whatever it takes to ruin his life, Renegade.

MAX FREEDOM (Uncle Sam with muscles) is passed out on the canvas while RENEGADE (every bully you've ever known), exhausted, tries to move towards his opponent.

MIKE ASH (O.C.) (CONT'D)

Both men are down! This is still anyone's match!

Renegade manages to get to his knees and pulls Max up with him.

BOOM! Renegade throws a punch. POW! Max answers. They trade blows as the crowd "oohs" and "ahhs" with every hit.

Max jumps up for an acrobatic move, but when he lands --

POP!

MAX

OW! SHIT! I think I just broke my knee!

REFEREE

Shut up and wrestle, kid.

Renegade grabs Max by the injured leg, unaware, and drags him to the center of the ring. Max tries to wave Renegade off, but he ignores him in true villain fashion.

Renegade specifically targets Max's bad knee for good show, and Max wails in pain after every hit.

MAX
FUCK! DICK! SHIT! STOP I'M REALLY
INJURED!

RENEGADE
(finally getting it)
Oh nooooooooo, I'm so sorry. Are you
okay?

The referee overhears this and hurriedly reports the injury
to his headset.

In the blink of an eye, the referee gets a response and moves
closer to instruct Renegade.

REFEREE
New finish. Pin him.

Renegade's eyes go wide and they meet Max's.

Max knows his expression and tries to crawl out of the ring
to escape his fate, but Renegade catches him by the bad leg
and drags him again. Max's pain is audible once more.

Renegade stands Max up, he puts him on his shoulder, and

RENEGADE
(in Max's ear)
I'm sorry, but I have to do this.

SLAM! Max goes down.

Renegade pins Max, and the referee slides into the count:

1, 2, 3. DING! DING! DING!

Renegade wins.

New Champ.

The sound of the boos begins to fade out as we --

ZOOM OUT:

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - LOBBY - THE NEXT DAY

The results of the match play out on a TV as FREDDIE URICH
(20s, thinks he knows better) uses the remote to mute it.

FREDDIE
Wow, that's the fakest thing I've
ever seen in my life.

From the corner of the room, a door is opened by a secretary in work pants and a polo donning the famous W Logo of the wrestling brand.

SECRETARY

Freddie Urich, interviewing for
staff writer?

FREDDIE

That's me!

SECRETARY

Right this way.

Titles: **THE SQUARED CIRCLE**

ACT ONE

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - SHEILA'S OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

The secretary leads Freddie into an office whose door reads :
"Sheila Trace - Head Writer".

Freddie has a seat across an empty desk.

FREDDIE

Thanks. Am I supposed to-

The secretary leaves without a word.

FREDDIE (CONT'D)

O-kay...

Freddie takes the time to look around the room.

His eyes land on an authentic championship belt.

Before touching it, he looks around - coast is clear. He
tries to pick it up, but immediately misjudges the weight and
falls to the floor.

SHEILA (O.C.)

Freddie Urich?

FREDDIE

I'm sorry!

SHEILA TRACE (47) stands above Freddie glaring down at him,
clipboard in hand.

SHEILA

Are you on the floor?

FREDDIE

Me? No, this belt fell, I was just
going to pick it up, but yeah.

SHEILA

Uh-huh. Nice to meet you. Are you
ready to start?

Freddie jumps up.

FREDDIE

The interview?

SHEILA

Oh, you want to be interviewed?
Sure, we can do that right now. Can
you tell me about some of your
experience? Your manager, Jack, I
think--

FREDDIE

(Rushing past it)
--That's the one! Good friend of
mine, Jack.

SHEILA

Yeah, he spoke about some
commercial work you've done.
(looks down at notes)
Baby wipes, dog food --

FREDDIE

Talking dog! Actually pretty funny.

SHEILA

-- Anti-Bullying PSA and Bullying
PSA? I thought that was weird.

FREDDIE

That must be some mistake.

SHEILA

He also told me you worked on a
movie franchise?

FREDDIE

Yes, of course! The franchise!
Yeah, I worked on three films, all
sequels, but all distinct. Really
stretched my creative muscles.

SHEILA

Yeah, he mentioned it was a passion
project, still unproduced.

FREDDIE

I'm not sure how he'd know that,
we're not that close.

SHEILA

Anyway, we're really not looking
for any of this.

FREDDIE

Well, I can have a passion for
other things and I'm a really quick
learner.

SHEILA

Alright, what do you think we could improve with WWE?

FREDDIE

Where do I start? You guys should hire better actors. Also the costumes look stupid, and that belt does not feel real at all. I would tell you to hire a better writer, but --

He does a bow.

SHEILA

I'm the head writer.

FREDDIE

(grimacing)

Love the work, huge fan.

SHEILA

You've got a lot to learn. Follow me. Also, wear this.

She slaps a sticky tag on him that reads: NOT A WRESTLER.

Freddie looks confused, but follows her lead anyway.

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - CONTROL ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The pair walk into what looks like the cockpit of an airplane. Screens, buttons, and wires - lots of wires - cover every inch of this room except for a wall of windows that look down into the arena.

In the arena, a crew of WORKERS can be seen preparing the ring in the middle, the screens around the arena, and the stage where wrestlers walk down from.

A couple of Crew Members sit inside the control room at different monitors, tinkering or editing footage, without acknowledging their presence.

SHEILA

This is the show of it. Everything you see on TV and down there,
(points out the windows)
Is managed up here.

FREDDIE

Wow, this is like a real movie studio.

SHEILA
Yup, we've got pyro too.

FREDDIE
Pyro?

SHEILA
Sally.

SALLY turns her head, and Sheila gives her a nod. She presses one button and --

BOOM!

Two walls of fire ERUPT near the stage inside of the arena. Freddie jumps back a little.

SHEILA (CONT'D)
Sally's the best and Fireworks are some of the best parts of the show.

FREDDIE
Can I try pressing one --

SHEILA
Absolutely not, Sally will set you on fire if you try.

Freddie gives half a laugh then spots Sally's death stare, and drops the smile.

SHEILA (CONT'D)
I need you to see this.

Sheila motions Freddie towards a monitor, and a match comes alive.

SHEILA (CONT'D)
This is what happened last night at our Pay-Per View.

Freddie watches the events of the teaser unfold.

FREDDIE
Yeah I saw this match in the lobby. I don't get why you made that guy look hurt when it was so obviously fake.

SHEILA
I'm glad you think so, because that was our star and he got injured for real. Now we have a new champion that everyone hates.

FREDDIE
Why is that bad?

SHEILA
Fans aren't happy, the show doesn't
run and we lose our jobs.

FREDDIE
Damn. So, what are you going to do?

SHEILA
That's where you come in. Let's see
what the degree can do. I'll give
you one shot today to prove
yourself, what do you say?

FREDDIE
I --

Brring!

Freddie looks down at his phone.

FREDDIE (CONT'D)
Hold on, that's my manager.
(into the phone)
Jack, my man, how's it going? Any
more offers?

The volume on the phone is just loud enough for Sheila to
hear.

MOM (O.S.)
Where have you been, sweetheart?
I've been worried sick.

Sheila glares judgingly.

SHEILA
(mouthing sarcastically)
Your manager?

Freddie gives a nervous smile.

FREDDIE
Sorry, Mom, I've just been working
really hard.

MOM
OH! Did someone say they'd shoot
your movie?!

FREDDIE
Not exactly --

MOM

Frederick! It's time you come home!
We can get you working at Dad's
shop. Why don't we just fly you
home?!

Freddie begins to sweat under the pressure. He looks to
Sheila and makes a split decision.

FREDDIE

Mom, I've actually got a new job,
but I've got to go now, we'll talk
later. Bye.

Freddie hangs up and keeps his head down as he slowly puts
his phone away.

SHEILA

So... Jack wouldn't happen to be
your mom?

FREDDIE

Nope. No.

SHEILA

That's what I thought. Ready to get
started?

FREDDIE

Ready as I'll ever be.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - WRITERS ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Sheila leads Freddie to a conference table with many empty chairs.

SHEILA
This is the writer's room.

FREDDIE
And the writers?

SHEILA
All quit. So, this kingdom is ours.

FREDDIE
Does this kingdom have a bathroom?

SHEILA
Out the door, first door to the left. Don't be long though, we have a show tonight we have to start planning.

FREDDIE
(sarcastically)
I'll pee like my life's on the line.

SHEILA
It is.

Freddie leaves with a pit in his stomach.

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Freddie walks into a bathroom with one stall, and two urinals, one of each is occupied with a man in wrestling gear.

Freddie begins to use the other one, but immediately is stunned when he recognizes Max Freedom peeing next to him.

FREDDIE
Hold on, is Max Freedom peeing next to me? Dude, huge fan. Had no idea you peed. You rock.

MAX
Don't mention it.

FREDDIE
So, do you wear your gear
everywhere you go?

MAX
No, seriously shut up. I'm doing
business over here.

FREDDIE
Sorry, Mr. Freedom... you wouldn't
happen to be related to a Dr.
Freedom would you?

FLUSH!

Max walks out annoyed.

Freddie shrugs the interaction off.

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - WRITERS ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Freddie returns from his bathroom adventures to find Sheila
taking notes at the table.

FREDDIE
All fresh and ready to go. Where do
we start?

SLAM!

Freddie's cut off by the door flying off its hinges as Mr.
Kennedy barrels in, angry as ever.

MR. KENNEDY
Sheila, who the hell is this? I
didn't authorize you to hire anyone
new. This is issue was yours to fix
alone.

SHEILA
Who, this? This is my cousin.

MR. KENNEDY
You don't have cousins, I know
you're entire family!

SHEILA
What's my mom's name.

MR. KENNEDY
Sheila?

SHEILA

Huh?

MR. KENNEDY

(to Freddie)

You need to leave the property
immediately.

FREDDIE

I understand.

SHEILA

I haven't even hired him, he's just
interviewing!

MR. KENNEDY

If he's still here at the end of
the day, you're both gone.

With that, Mr. Kennedy storms away.

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - HALLWAY - SAME TIME

Max hears the commotion from behind the writers' room door,
and perks up when Mr. Kennedy threatens Sheila.

Just then, Renegade appears behind him.

RENEGADE

What the hell are you doing here,
Max, shouldn't you be in rehab?

MAX

None of your business, you should
rehab your face.

Renegade rolls his eyes.

Mr. Kennedy blasts through the doors, and Max tries to get
his attention.

MAX (CONT'D)

Sir, I need to talk to you about --

MR. KENNEDY

Not now, kid. Find someone else to
bother.

Max tenses, and Renegade smirks at him before heading into --

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - WRITERS ROOM - CONTINUOUS

SHEILA

Kurt, what is up with him?

RENEGADE

People aren't happy about the title change, you know how he gets. Who's this?

SHEILA

This is Freddie. He's a writer, do you think you guys could work together on your promo tonight?

FREDDIE

You guys having a merch sale or something?

RENEGADE

I have to give a speech tonight to address my win.

FREDDIE

Oh perfect, I've read a lot of Shakespearean soliloquies.

RENEGADE

What's that?

SHEILA

Don't worry about it, teach him as you go, yeah?

RENEGADE

Whatever you say, boss.

INT. WWE HEADQUARTERS - PERFORMANCE CENTER - MOMENTS LATER

The two walk into a massive gym populated with people doing all kinds of exercises. Most of the room is taken up by a couple full-sized wrestling rings where wrestlers are actively training.

RENEGADE

This is where superstars go over their matches before they do it live.

FREDDIE

Why are they called superstars?

Renegade points to a ring where one wrestler does a Backflip from the top rope.

FREDDIE (CONT'D)
Point taken. But it's all
choreographed right?

RENEGADE
Not always, most of it is
improvised. And there's good guys
and bad guys. You should be
familiar with that.

FREDDIE
What about anti-heroes? Grey areas?
Morally complex characters?

RENEGADE
Keep it simple. Good guys call the
shots, bad guys make them look
good. Then someone wins.

FREDDIE
How do people watch that every
week?

RENEGADE
It's the story. How's it any
different in your favorite show?

Freddie tries for a response, but gets caught in his words,
and they move on.

They walk over to an empty ring and Renegade slides under the
ropes to get in.

FREDDIE
How do I--

RENEGADE
There's stairs like right there.

Freddie uses the stairs near the apron to get in too.

FREDDIE
So, how do you usually do this?

RENEGADE
Nothing much, run the ropes, wait
till an idea hits me. What about
you?

FREDDIE

Me? I studied screenwriting, this is new for me.

RENEGADE

Sure, but where do you get your ideas from?

Freddie is caught slightly off guard by this question.

FREDDIE

Recently, I've just been thinking about my life a lot. Try to find stories in what I've lived. Half the time my mom pressures me into something.

RENEGADE

I've definitely had that.

FREDDIE

Who's your mom?

RENEGADE

My dad owns the company, you met him, didn't he fire you like fifteen minutes ago?

FREDDIE

Didn't know Renegade was the son's boss.

RENEGADE

It's just Kurt, but yeah. I don't like it any more than others do.

FREDDIE

If it wasn't for my mom I wouldn't be here. But, I kind of need to be here.

RENEGADE

Then we better think of something my dad will like.

FREDDIE

But if it's just a story, isn't all that matters making sure the audience likes it?

RENEGADE

What's your point?

FREDDIE
Screw your dad.

RENEGADE
I agree, but elaborate.

FREDDIE
No, seriously, let's blame your dad
for the title change.

RENEGADE
We can't just say that.

FREDDIE
Why not? Only villain bigger than
you is the guy who made this really
happen.

RENEGADE
(half convinced)
You think the crowd will believe
that?

FREDDIE
Who cares. Either they do and you
no longer have heat or you make a
name for yourself making your dad
look stupid. What do you say?

RENEGADE
It'll never work. He'll shut it
down before we can --

FREDDIE
What's stopping you from trying?

Renegade stops in the middle of the ring, and looks around
nervously. Then, he lets out an anxious breath.

RENEGADE
Let's do it, you're right.

FREDDIE
Yeah! Let's make the crowd feel
something!

RENEGADE
Sheila's not going to like this.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

INT. KASEYA CENTER - SHOW TAPING - LIVE IN TEN

A packed Miami crowd cheers as a countdown to showtime nears its end.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - BACKSTAGE - SAME TIME

Renegade finds Freddie and Sheila stand in front of monitors as they prepare to watch the show.

RENEGADE

Hey, so I like what we talked about.

SHEILA

You have to own it, otherwise it's not going to work.

FREDDIE

Wait, so we're going with my idea?

SHEILA

Yeah, and if they crowd don't like it, then you're fired.

FREDDIE

Seriously?!

SHEILA

Well...

RENEGADE

Hey, so am I good to go?

SHEILA

Yeah, get ready to walk out.

RENEGADE

Thanks guys. Freddie, we got this, don't worry.

Freddie gives a nervous smile and Renegade runs off.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - SHOW TIME

Music hits, and fireworks light up the arena to begin the show.

MIKE ASH (O.C.)

We are LIVE! In Miami, Florida, home of WWE Headquarters, and last night things were shaken up. In an unexpected win, Renegade defeated Max Freedom and became World Champion for the first time in his career! News outlets were shocked, fans were shocked, and now we await Renegade's first address since winning the gold.

Renegade's music hits promptly, and he walks out on to the stage. He makes a big show of lifting the championship belt up, and the crowd responds in a flurry of boos.

He makes his way down the stage and into the ring where someone throws him a microphone.

RENEGADE

Boo all you want, Miami! That doesn't change the fact that I'm your NEW WORLD CHAMPION!

He lifts the belt again to get an even louder flurry of boos.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)

First of all, I want to thank Max for giving me the easiest fight of my life.

Renegade pauses to smile before continuing, soaking up the crowd's energy.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)

I was going to keep talking about Max, because I know you all love him so much, but then I thought: He's old news, who wants to talk about last weeks champion?

The crowd gives louder boos.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)

The truth is, Max was only relevant because of me. I'm the one you guys make noise for. There's no competition without me. Those clips you watch online, I made those. Every headline has my name in it. You paid your tickets to see me whether you like it or not and I run this show!

CROWD
(chanting)
We want Max! We want Max!

RENEGADE
I hear you loud and clear, but
guess what? He's in some stupid
hospital getting his stupid ankle
fixed by some stupid doctor.

The crowd boos more.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)
But let me tell you why that's good
news. Now I get to challenge
whoever I want. Remember all your
other favorite wrestlers who never
got a chance because Max Freedom
only cared about himself? Now that
Max is gone, I could have a match
with the Destroyer.

Light "oohs" can be heard.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)
I could have a cage match with Josh
Briggs?

Now some cheers make themselves heard.

RENEGADE (CONT'D)
No I got it, I know what you guys
want. Me vs Trick Visca, wait for
it, No Holds Barred.

The crowd actually starts cheering in favor of this.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - BACKSTAGE - SAME TIME

Freddie and Sheila get excited as the crowd begin to cheer
louder.

FREDDIE
I think it's working.

SHEILA
It's hard to believe, but that
crowd is cheering.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - SHOW TAPING - SAME TIME

RENEGADE

I can't hear you, is that what you want?!

CROWD

Yes! Yes! Yes!

Just then, Max's music hits and the crowd erupts in cheers.

Max emerges in a pair of crutches and hobbles down the ramp.

He grabs a nearby microphone and climbs the steps into the ring.

MAX

I'm back everyone, and I'm not that hurt.

RENEGADE

What is this clown doing in my ring?

INT. KASEYA CENTER - BACKSTAGE - SAME TIME

FREDDIE

What the hell is happening?

SHEILA

I hate this fucking company.

FREDDIE

No seriously, he can just walk out there anytime he wants?

SHEILA

(ignoring him)

Where's Mr. Kennedy?

INT. KASEYA CENTER - SHOW TAPING - SAME TIME

Max and Freddie now stand opposite each other in the ring, having the stupidest stare down.

RENEGADE

(off the mic)

Don't do this, Max. We can figure this out backstage.

MAX

(into the mic)

I'm back everyone. I couldn't help, but answer Renegade's begging, and I wanted to grace him with my presence.

RENEGADE

Max, stop talking before I send you back to the hospital.

MAX

(ignoring him)

Your new champ is afraid. He only beat me when I was weak. He was too afraid to give me a fair fight. He was too afraid to fight me with honor. He was too afraid to rely on himself alone to win.

RENEGADE

That's ironic, because the only reason you've been a champion for so long is you've been afraid to be anything else.

MAX

(off the mic)

You can't say that.

RENEGADE

I'm not afraid to call it how it is. Max Freedom is a joke. I know that, they know that, and Mr. Kennedy knows it too.

The crowd gives a large gasp at the owner's mention.

MAX

(off the mic)

Shut up, Kurt.

RENEGADE

The reason I have this title is because my father, your boss, lost interest in a crybaby, wannabe American hero. So he gave it to the only person who deserves it, his son!

MAX

(into the mic)

Hey, that's not --

RENEGADE

No, I'm not done! My dad is a screw up who can't control his talent. He's the reason the show's gone to shit, and he's the reason that I'm going to take over.

In a turn of events, the crowd starts chanting swear words.

CROWD

Ass-hole! Ass-hole! Ass-hole!

RENEGADE

The worst part is --

Suddenly, there's no sound. Renegade's lips keep moving, but nothing can be heard. The microphone was cut.

Renegade shakes the mic awkwardly, but nothing seems to work.

All of a sudden, Renegade's music hits.

Renegade and Max appear to cuss each other out, before Renegade leaves the ring and makes his way up the stage - music still drowning everything out.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - BACKSTAGE

FREDDIE

I can't believe it, I think it worked.

SHEILA

A little too well, we're going to have to censor the hell out of that.

Renegade finally catches up.

RENEGADE

That's it, we got him. Either this blows up in our face or --

FREDDIE

You just became the biggest star in the company.

Renegade can't help but laugh at the thought of it.

Just then, Max bursts onto the scene.

MAX

What was that shit show?!

SHEILA

You had no business being out there, Max, you weren't booked tonight!

MAX

HELL IF I CARE! I'm champ, I can do what I want.

FREDDIE

You're not champ, Renegade is.

MAX

Who the hell do you think you are?

RENEGADE

Pipe down.

MAX

Pipe down? After that pipe bomb? You think you're still working here after that? I don't care who your dad is, you're done.

RENEGADE

You don't call the shots around here.

MAX

I do! You, the kid, and the bitch are done here! I'm going to Kennedy myself.

Max storms out of the room.

RENEGADE

This dipshit.

Renegade gives Freddie and Sheila a look, then chases after them.

SHEILA

This isn't going to be good. C'mon.

Sheila and Freddie follow suit.

INT. KASEYA CENTER - KENNEDY'S OFFICE

Sheila and Freddie make it to the room to find Max and Renegade standing silently as they watch Mr. Kennedy pack things off his desk.

RENEGADE

Dad, what's going on?

MR. KENNEDY

I just had a phone call with the board of directors. Per their majority vote, they've made the executive decision to suspend me from service indefinitely.

MAX

What does that even mean? Who's going to run this place?

MR. KENNEDY

There will be someone to fill my role, that has yet to be decided. But, Sheila Trace will remain acting CEO until that time.

SHEILA

CEO?

MR. KENNEDY

Acting CEO. I may not work here at the moment, but I still own this damn company.

RENEGADE

Are we keeping the title on me? That was your call, is that going to change?

MR. KENNEDY

Like you said, I'm a "screw up". That's for you all to screw back in.

He lifts his head to meet their eyes for the first time.

MR. KENNEDY (CONT'D)

Don't think for a second that I won't have my way in things.

SHEILA

We'll be ready when you're back.

MR. KENNEDY

Don't worry, it'll be like I never left.

With that, Mr. Kennedy takes his things and leaves.

The rest of the group remain stunned.

FREDDIE

Hey guys, do I still have a job?

SHEILA

Only one way to find out. Let's get
to work.

END OF EPISODE